Cyberbullying: A Digital Crime Case Study

What is Cyberbullying?

Cyberbullying is "the use of digital technology to harass, threaten, intimidate, mock, or humiliate another person." Unlike other types of bullying, cyberbullying can be done "24/7." This is because of the anonymity that is often associated with the Internet. Cyberbullying can be done through spreading rumors, posting embarrassing photos without permission, and making threats through messages and other forms of online communications.

How Cyberbullying Typically Occurs

1. The bully selects a person to bully.
2. The bully collects personal information about the person to be bullied.
3. The bully starts to bully the person through messages and other forms of online communications.
4. Other people join in on the bullying through spreading the bully's messages and communications to other people and through other means of online communications.
5. The person who is bullied becomes socially isolated because cyberbullying can spread very fast.

Who is Usually Targeted?

Cyberbullying is usually directed to people who are perceived to be different and vulnerable. New students, people with disabilities, gays and lesbians, and minorities are often targeted. However, anyone can be targeted. According to research, "37% of youth ages 12-17 have experienced cyberbullying."

Consequences of Cyberbullying

The effects are severe and wide-ranging. Victims may develop anxiety, depression, poor academic results, and social isolation. In extreme cases, it has even led to self-injury and suicide. According to the Cyberbullying Research Center, victims are twice as likely to even attempt suicide. The bullies may face legal consequences such as being charged or suspended from school.

Source: *Cyberbullying Research Center (https://cyberbullying.org), 2023 Statistics.*